when he came to watch me play tennis. I once asked him why. He said he thought that I might get nervous or feel extra pressure if I saw him standing beside the court.

We used to visit his house, where he would typically sit on the verandah reading the newspaper. Nobody was supposed to disturb him there but, as an indulged grandson, I was allowed to hit tennis balls against the wall behind him. As the ball passed inches from his head, over and again, he never moved or said a word.

My father has three sisters: Tannie Leens, who lives in Stellenbosch with her husband, WP Oosthuizen, and their three daughters, Anneke, Suzanne and Leentjie – I was always exceptionally close to Leentjie, because she was a fine tennis player and we spent a great deal of time together on the junior circuit; Tannie Gerbre, who lives in Mossel Bay with her husband, Harry Hill, and their children Vincent and Eleanor; and Tannie Suzanne, who still lives in Pretoria with her husband, Jurie van der Walt, and their four children, Jana, Riaan, who is my age and went to school with me, Eric and Jurie.

My mother's maiden name was Wessels and her family lived in Pretoria. Her father, Oupa Hans, was a bank manager at a number of Volkskas branches around the country before becoming head manager at the Volkskas head office; he and his wife Ramona had three daughters, Annette, my mum, then Wilna, and the three De Villiers boys were the only grandchildren.

When my Oupa Hans fell ill, he and Ramona moved to Bela-Bela to be closer to my mother. When he passed away he was buried in the town cemetery, and Ramona bought property in a retirement village and she is still going strong, still supporting her grandsons, enthusiastically watching the cricket on television with her friends.

Like many families in the northern part of the country, we drove to the coast each summer, spending the Christmas holidays moving from one family to the other. Oupa Hans and the Wessels family were usually